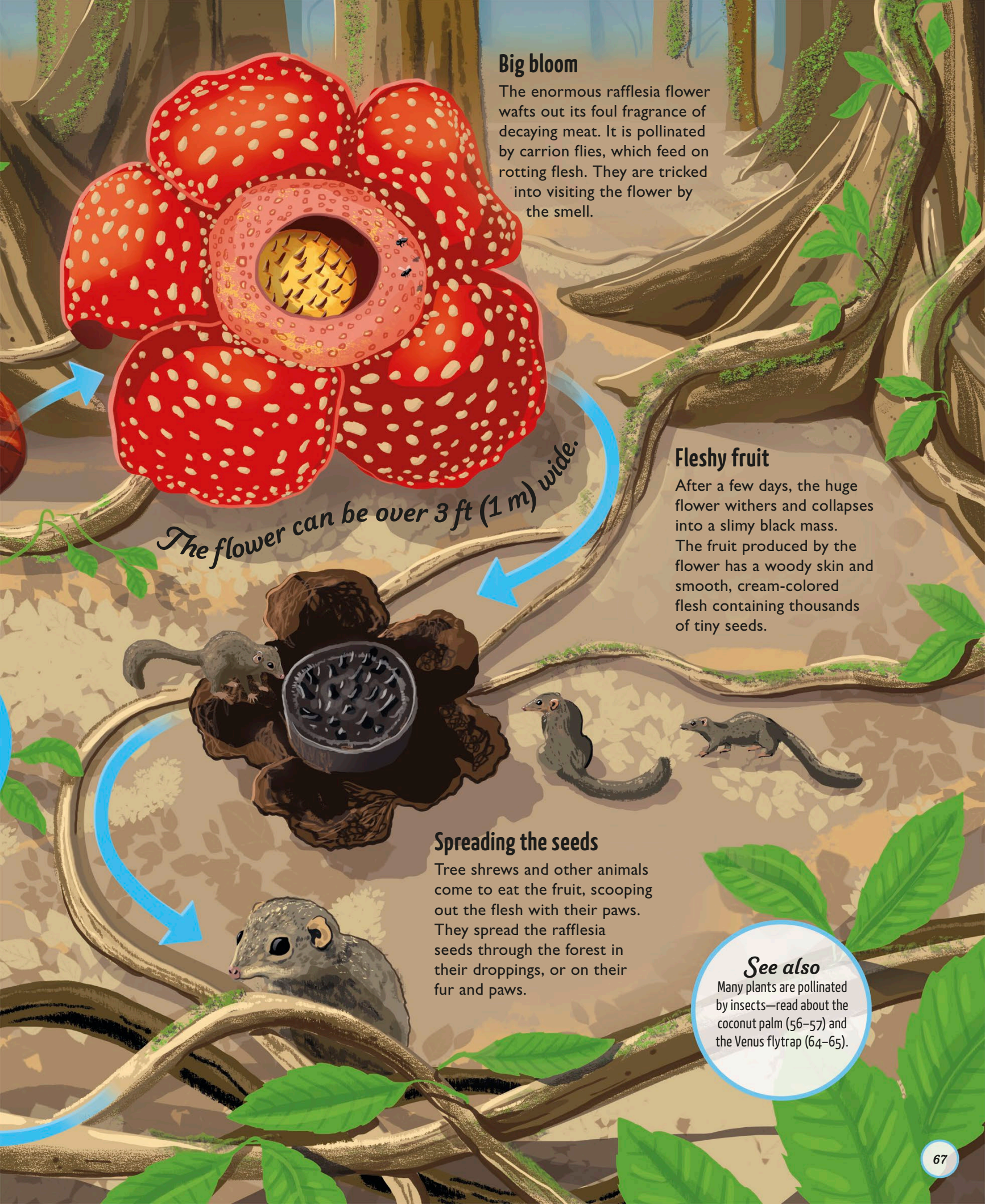




Big bloom

The enormous rafflesia flower wafts out its foul fragrance of decaying meat. It is pollinated by carrion flies, which feed on rotting flesh. They are tricked into visiting the flower by the smell.

The flower can be over 3 ft (1 m) wide.

Fleshy fruit

After a few days, the huge flower withers and collapses into a slimy black mass. The fruit produced by the flower has a woody skin and smooth, cream-colored flesh containing thousands of tiny seeds.

Spreading the seeds

Tree shrews and other animals come to eat the fruit, scooping out the flesh with their paws. They spread the rafflesia seeds through the forest in their droppings, or on their fur and paws.

See also

Many plants are pollinated by insects—read about the coconut palm (56–57) and the Venus flytrap (64–65).